

Lone wolf on 64 squares

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In a field of 128 elite competitors, Nihal Sarin has done what no other Indian player could — secure a direct invitation to the Esports Nations Cup (ENC) 2026 Chess main event through the official Champions Chess Tour (CCT) Leaderboard.

The 64 direct invites were capped at one per country, and Sarin's consistency across the Speed Chess Championship 2025, Chess.com Open 2026 (CCO), and the Titled Tuesday Grand Prix (TTGP) saw him accumulate 139 leaderboard points, placing him among the top six players globally.

The journey, however, was not a bed of roses.

Sarin narrowly missed direct qualification through the CCO 2026 by a single spot. But he rebounded with 100 crucial points and added more across the TTGP splits. His name now sits alongside legends like Magnus Carlsen, Hikaru Nakamura, and Alireza Firouzja.

The Chess competition runs from November 2–8, 2026, with a USD 600,000 prize pool. India can still send a second player via regional qualifiers (June 6–7 and June 13–14). Sarin, representing S8UL, has already punched his ticket.

Rocket League: Chemistry Meets Ambition

While Sarin enjoys a direct route, India's Rocket League squad must earn its place. The roster—Abhai "Abscrazy" Ponna, Karthik "Karvin" Raghunandan, Aditeya "Riyal" Srivastav, and substitute Jayanth "Orjanguse" Engineer—will enter the Asia regional qualifiers (July 17–19), where only three nations advance.

Abscrazy, one of India's most decorated Rocket League players (Esportz Premier Series 2022 champion, RLCS Major competitor), has previously teamed with Karvin and Riyal under the banner of Big Dawgs. The trio recently played together at the FIFAE Nations League Week 1, securing a top-four finish. Coach Nirjhar "jocse" Mitra, appointed by NODWIN Gaming, has deliberately built on that existing synergy.

The ENC 2026 Rocket League tournament features 48 national teams, a USD 1.32 million prize pool, and runs from November 2–8. Twenty-four teams received direct invites via RLCS rankings; India sits outside that bracket but enters the qualifiers with momentum and proven coordination.

Esports World Cup shifted to Paris from Riyadh

For two blistering years, Riyadh was the undisputed home of the Esports World Cup. But geopolitics forced a hard reset, with West Asia caught in the crossfire of escalating air strikes by Israel and the United States on Iran.

As a result, the 2026 edition of the World Cup will now be held under the shadow of the Eiffel Tower instead.

From July 6 to August 23, the seven-week festival of fragging and finesse will unfold.

Over 2,000 players representing 200 Clubs from more than 100 countries will descend upon France. They will fight across 24 game titles and 25 individual tournaments, all chasing a slice of a gigantic prize pool of over USD 75 million.